

If-then plans

Tie the action to a moment. "If it is 7am and I have eaten, then I practise for twenty minutes." Deciding once, so you never have to decide again.

FOR A HABIT · PETER GOLLWITZER, 1999 · TAKES TEN MINUTES

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write the goal in one line. Then forget it; the method is about the moments, not the goal.
2. List the moments when you could act: a time, a place, something that happens. "After I put my bag down." "When the 3.15 bell goes."
3. For each, write one line: "If [moment], then I will [action]." The action is small and specific enough that there is nothing to work out when the moment comes.
4. Write one more for the obstacle: "If I feel like skipping it, then I will [do the smallest version]."
5. Put the lines where the moments happen: on the bag, by the kettle, in the phone's lock screen. They are not for remembering the goal. They are for recognising the moment.
6. Review once a week. A line that never fired has the wrong moment; change the moment, not the goal.

Where it falls down. Writing the goal again in if-then clothing: "If it is Monday, then I will be more organised" has no moment and no action.

WITH A PEN

The goal, in one line

Then leave it alone

If [moment]

A time, a place, something that happens

then I will [action]

Small enough that there is nothing to work out

If

then I will

If

then I will

If I feel like skipping it

then I will

The smallest version

Where each line lives, and when I review them